supreme source of meaning and authority lies within ourselves, it is far more important to know what *you* think about these matters. Ask a teacher – whether in kindergarten, school or college – what she is trying to teach. "Well," she will answer, "I teach my students history, or quantum physics, or art – but above all I try to teach them to think for themselves." It may not always succeed, but that is what liberal education seeks to do.

In Western political discourse the term "liberal" is sometimes used today in a much narrower partisan sense, as the opposite of "conservative." In the USA, for example, liberals are thought to be people who vote for the Democratic Party, and who support specific causes like gay marriage, gun control, and abortion. But in truth, most conservatives nowadays also embrace the broad liberal worldview. Especially in the United States, both Republicans and Democrats should occasionally take a break from their heated quarrels to remind themselves that they all agree on fundamentals such as free elections, free markets, and human rights.

Test yourself. Do you think people should have the liberty to choose their government rather than servilely obey a king? Do you think people should have the liberty to choose their profession rather than be born into a predetermined caste? Do you think people should have the liberty to choose their spouse rather than marrying whomever their parents select for them? Do you think people should have the liberty to choose their religion rather than be forced to follow some state-imposed creed? If you answered yes to these questions, and you think people should enjoy such liberties, then congratulations – you are a liberal!

In recent centuries, liberalism has won numerous converts, and has transformed our understanding of politics, ethics, economics, art and education. Yet at the dawn of the third millennium, the future of liberalism is unclear. A huge gulf is opening between the tenets of liberalism and the latest findings of the life sciences, a gulf we cannot ignore much longer. Our liberal systems are founded on the belief in the sanctity of our feelings and of our free choices, which are supposed to give meaning to the world, and be the source of all authority. Yet the life sciences are questioning this belief. Scientists studying where our feelings come from, and how our choices are actually made, argue that what we feel and do is determined by hormones, genes and synapses, rather than by some mystical free will – the same forces that determine the behaviour of chimpanzees, wolves and ants.